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Ecological Statecraft for Hegemonic Visions: The Governance of Chengdu Eco-Zone Over Two Decades

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ABSTRACT

This study advances urban political ecology (UPE) by examining how ecological space production has become a key terrain for pursuing a hegemonic project of ecological civilisation in China. 'Ecological statecraft' provides a framework for examining how the ecological visions are materialised in the Chengdu Eco-Zone. The area transformed from a landscape of mixed villages and construction in the 2000s to a hybrid of greenways and farmlands in the 2020s. These dramatic 'shifts' reveal a persistent logic of the ruling party, even as specific visions are continually reshaped in response to changing domestic and external conditions. Our analysis situates state politics within broader UPE debates, particularly historical materialist and Southern everyday-state perspectives, and brings them into dialogue with Chinese UPE scholarship on state power, land politics and ecological territorialisation. In particular, combining statecraft and everyday-state perspectives reveals how state-dominated ecological governance is increasingly co-shaped by grassroots interests and practices.

摘要

本文从城市政治生态学的视角出发, 考察生态空间生产如何成为中国推进生态文明这一总体性政治愿景的重要实践领域。文章提出"生态治术"(ecological statecraft)这一分析框架, 用以解释生态愿景如何在成都环城生态区转化为空间、制度与治理实践。自2000年代以来, 这一区域经历了显著变化:从村庄、农地与建设活动交错的城乡过渡地带, 逐步转变为到2020年后以绿道和农田为主要形态的复合生态空间。通过研究这些剧烈的空间与政策转向的机制, 本文揭示尽管具体的生态愿景会随着国内外环境的变化不断调整, 其始终遵循一种政治导向的治理逻辑, 即通过生态空间建设回应不同阶段的发展目标, 并不断重塑国家治理的空间形式。本文将这一过程置于更广泛的城市政治生态学讨论之中, 特别是历史唯物主义以及全球南方关于"日常国家"的研究, 并与中国城市政治生态学关于国家权力、土地政治和生态领土化的研究展开对话。通过结合"生态治术"与"日常国家"的视角, 本文进一步指出, 即使在国家主导的生态治理中, 地方社会的利益诉求、日常实践与基层互动也日益参与塑造治理过程及其实际结果。

1 | Introduction

The production and reproduction of ecological spaces as socio-political reconfiguration have been widely explored (Swyngedouw and Heynen 2003). What it means for these struggles to be 'political' and how this politicisation takes shape are geographical issues (Gandy 2022; Harvey 1996). Earlier interpretations positioned such struggles in opposition to capitalist formations (Heynen et al. 2006). More recent critiques draw on plural geographies beyond Western contexts (Cornea et al. 2017; Lawhon et al. 2014). Among these debates, the uneasy relationship between political ecology and state power stands out (Loftus 2020). Perhaps for this reason, although studies of China's ecological governance have

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foregrounded the state (Deng et al. 2026a; Rodenbiker 2023; Smith 2021; Yeh 2013), sustained theoretical engagement with broader UPE scholarship remains limited (for exceptions, see Chung et al. 2018; Wang et al. 2023; Xie et al. 2019; Xie and Den Hartog 2026).

We propose to bridge the gap with a 'statecraft' approach and examine how ecological space production has become an increasingly important terrain through which the hegemonic project of ecological civilisation is materialised and contested in China. Such a project emphasises both ideational and material forces (Yeh 2013) in ecological space-making and restructuring. Ecology is not only a scientific term but also a 'multimodal signifier within and through which nested relations between the state, society, and nature articulate' (Rodenbiker 2023, 2). In the era of ecological civilisation, ideological and material expressions of ecology are increasingly dominated by the state.

Hegemonic projects are associated with consent-building and non-coercive domination (Althusser 2014; Jessop 2007), which appear to sit uneasily with accounts of China's environmental authoritarianism that emphasise limited consent and non-participatory governance. However, hegemonic projects are never complete. Hegemonic visions defining the 'nature and purposes of government for the wider society' evolve with shifting state strategies driven by the imperatives of sustaining capital accumulation and maintaining internal cohesion (Jessop 2010, 49). They have to combine both coercion and consent (Yeh 2013). Such a framing directs attention to the ongoing tension between hegemonic visions and the practices and counterforces that (un)make them.

Empirically, we focus on the restructuring of Chengdu's 187 km^2 peri-urban ecological protection zone (the 'Eco-Zone') over two decades. Since its demarcation by the municipal government around 2001, the Eco-Zone has experienced substantial spatial change. In the 2000s, it was a mosaic of villages and construction sites; in the 2010s, greenways, parks and housing developments were introduced. By the 2020s, the municipal government had formed an agricultural company to convert large landscaped areas to farmland.

We develop the framework 'ecological statecraft' to bring state politics within broader UPE—particularly the historical materialist tradition and Southern everyday state perspectives—into dialogue with Chinese ecological governance scholarship. The framework enables us to examine state power through concrete relations, struggles and injustices rather than rushing into abstraction (Loftus 2020). It views the state not as a monolithic entity but as a constellation of actors and institutions (Deng et al. 2026c; Jessop 2007; Pike 2023), yielding two analytical insights. First, by extending historical-materialist UPE's focus on the state's role in safeguarding accumulation strategies with insights from Chinese ecological governance scholarship, the framework analyses how strategically positioned state actors frame hegemonic ecological visions through the selective politicisation of ecological issues. Second, drawing on Southern UPE perspectives on the everyday state, the framework uncovers how less formal environmental practices are constitutive of ecological statecraft in China.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews understandings of state power in UPE, focusing on historical materialist and Southern everyday approaches, and their limited engagement with Chinese ecological governance. Section 3 examines the politics of ecological space production in China, highlighting land rights, shifting state strategies and the growing role of grassroots actors. Building on these insights, Section 4 develops the framework of ecological statecraft to analyse how ecological spaces are pursued as a hegemonic project in China. Section 5 introduces the Chengdu Eco-Zone case. Section 6 analyses the selective politicisation of the Eco-Zone governance by the municipal government amid contestations over land use and strategic priorities. Section 7 examines how state-owned enterprises and grassroots quasi-state actors mediate tensions between higher-level mandates and local communities. Section 8 examines how different social groups contest consent through the lens of 'incomplete hegemony.' The paper concludes by outlining how Chinese ecological governance contributes to broader UPE debates.

2 | State Power in Urban Political Ecology

Historical-materialist traditions of UPE treat ecological space production as a capitalist project (Swyngedouw and Heynen 2003). They understand socio-natural transformations as products of material metabolism by capital accumulation, asking 'who produces what kind of socio-ecological configurations for whom' (Heynen et al. 2006, 2). The notion of socio-ecological fix extends Marxist theories of spatial fixes by framing them as 'metabolic processes involving the production of space but also necessarily the transformation of socionatures, whether in urban or rural settings' (Ekers and Prudham 2017, 1381).

The research highlights the role of state authorities in safeguarding the conditions of capital accumulation (Crabb et al. 2024) and mediating capitalism's ecological contradictions (Collard and Dempsey 2026). Framing the state as the 'ultimate' landlord underscores its role in enforcing private property regimes and providing the infrastructure that enables resource extraction and rent capture (Parenti 2015). State authorities, as primary architects and agents, deliberately depoliticise and repoliticise the ecological fixes to reassert control (Cohen and Bakker 2014). On Chengdu's greenways, Zhang et al. (2022) use the concept of the socio-ecological fix to examine how greenways are designed to achieve a 'win–win' between economic growth and ecological quality, while also highlighting the centrality of state action through Chinese state entrepreneurialism (Wu and Zhang 2026; Zhang and Wu 2024).

However, these accounts tend to overemphasise the state's role in securing accumulation strategies, while underplaying alternative hegemonic agendas and the tensions between capitalist and territorial logics. In the Chengdu context, Deng et al. (2026a) critique 'fix' concepts for conflating political and capitalist elites, calling for closer attention to the territorial logic, which fundamentally contradicts capitalist logics (Wu et al. 2024).

A loosely categorised post-structural strand drawing on anthropological, postcolonial and feminist insights advocates a more

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situated understanding of environment, knowledge and power (Lawhon et al. 2014). Drawing on Southern experiences and Foucauldian approaches to dispersed power, Cornea et al. (2017) critique Marxist UPE traditions for privileging political–economic analyses that often depict urban socio-environments as shaped by top-down forces of capitalist hegemonies. Their analysis was grounded in everyday life in Southern urbanism, highlighting 'a variety of logics, intentionality and assemblages of the non-state, non-elite majority' (Lawhon et al. 2014, 507).

The post-structural approach has influenced Chinese scholarship. To understand how meanings are constructed and certain values come to dominate, scholars delve into processes through which such 'arrangements are inscribed and negotiated' (Xu and Chung 2024, 989). Before presupposing 'what' structures exist (e.g., capitalist or not), they prioritise questions of 'why' and 'how' domination is enacted and reproduced (Chung and Xu 2021). Emphasising the power of discourse, the research highlights the politicisation of ecological issues by state elites within China's political system. Meanwhile, Chinese scholars have critiqued the neoliberal environmentality approach for bypassing theorising state violence (Wang et al. 2023). This critique aligns with broader debates in UPE about its historically uneasy engagement with the state (Loftus 2020), and reflects the ambiguous position of China (or a Global East) within the North–South divide.

Importantly, Southern UPE studies foreground an everyday perspective on the environmental state. They enrich analyses of state power as it operates through street-level bureaucrats, local politicians and citizens (Cornea et al. 2017). In this framing, the everyday is not outside the state but a key terrain for analysing state power and state space. By compelling residents to navigate shifting bureaucratic arrangements to access basic resources, fragmentation spatialises authority and produces governable publics (Truelove and Cornea 2021). This everyday approach shifts attention from the imposition of state power to its exercise in ecological governance.

While UPE has expanded its empirical reach to the Global South, its penetration into East Asian scholarship remains limited (Gandy 2022). Despite numerous studies on the politics of ecological space-making in China, their potentially significant contributions to a more global UPE—particularly in bridging historical-materialist and more post-structuralist understandings of state power—remain underarticulated.

3 | Production of Ecological Spaces in China

The production of ecological space is closely tied to land politics, a key dimension of state power in China. The Marxist view of 'accumulation by dispossession' has been used to explain land-based social conflicts (Chen 2013; Lin 2009). China's dual land system separates state-owned urban land from collectively owned rural land. Land appropriation occurs when local governments—mainly at municipal and district levels—acquire land from rural collectives (Hsing 2010). Meanwhile, informal rural land transfers allow village collectives to lease farmlands for industrial and commercial use, bypassing formal and costly appropriation (Bray 2013). This accentuates unauthorised use of farmlands for non-agricultural purposes (Lin 2009) and 'rent-based regimes of accumulation' that exclude ordinary villagers from participation (Kan 2019, 639). Smith (2021) argues that state authorities maintain a 'disjunctural urbanisation' between fluid social processes and rigid administrative categories, such as the urban registration (hukou) system and collective rural land ownership. This deliberate disjunction reduces state welfare obligations while sustaining the Party's legitimacy rooted in rural land (Lim 2023).

In the era of 'ecological civilisation,' ecological territorialisation increasingly becomes 'key to producing new frontiers of conservation-oriented development and municipal state consolidation of power over rural spaces,' which involves the relocation of villagers and coercive reconfiguration of their identities (Rodenbiker 2023, 98). By converting the urban periphery into 'ecological spaces', such as green belts, wetlands and ecological parks, local governments visibly demonstrate political alignment with 'ecological civilisation' (Zhang et al. 2022).

These projects also enable value capture by increasing the price of adjacent property developments, and clearing rural land generates development quotas through transferable development rights (Chung et al. 2018). Although 'ecological protection redlines' were incorporated into the revised Environmental Protection Law in 2015, they remained one of several overlapping conservation designations administered by different central ministries (Yeh 2023). Municipal planners often overlaid new ecological designations onto existing agricultural or rural construction land (Rodenbiker 2023). They also mapped 'basic farmland' onto mountainous terrain to avoid constraining development in central urban areas (Lin 2009), including in Chengdu.

Recently, the role of local governments in ecological space-making in China has been reassessed in light of stronger central interventions (Wu et al. 2025) to address fragmentation as part of the broader 'environmental statecraft' (Deng et al. 2026c). The Territorial Spatial Planning (国土空间规划) reforms, rolled out nationwide following the reconfiguration of the Ministry of Natural Resources (MNR) in 2018, sought to replace urban planning and consolidate fragmented regulations governing spatial control 'redlines.' In 2019, the State Council required subnational governments to designate three mutually exclusive zones: permanent basic farmland, ecological protection areas and construction land within urban development boundaries, each governed by redlines. Yeh (2023) finds that Central Environmental Inspection Groups have enforced ecological redlines in Chengdu since 2017, leading to the demolition of residential and tourism facilities in a nature reserve. In Dali, the enforcement of 'ecological redlines' around Erhai Lake led to the relocation of over one thousand tourism homestay businesses and residents in 2018–2019 (Feng et al. 2024).

These dynamics speak to narratives highlighting how local governments deploy technocratic and bureaucratic tools to depoliticise ecological issues. Indeed, Pow (2018) argues that officials often deliberately frame ecological concerns in technical terms. Nature is rendered governable and measurable, allowing scientific discourse to obscure the violence of displacement and land expropriation (Rodenbiker 2023).

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However, Yeh (2023) argues that bureaucratic control provides a useful but incomplete explanatory framework for understanding ecological enforcement. Coercive regulation may secure compliance, but it does not amount to hegemony due to the lack of consent. Pow (2018) further shows that even persuasive governmental practices that make ecological visions attractive do not necessarily generate residents' consent; their hegemonic effects remain partial and contested. Rodenbiker (2023) similarly shows that relocated villagers in Chengdu are not passive victims but actively negotiate compensation schemes and engage in forms of aesthetic resistance.

The complexity suggests that 'accumulation by dispossession' may oversimplify uneven gains and losses across social groups such as 'exploited villagers' and 'urban elites' (Kan 2019). It risks reducing state violence to a mere strategy for sustaining accumulation. Meanwhile, post-structural UPE perspectives emphasise that politicisation is not confined to bottom-up actors but also involves state elites (Chung and Xu 2021; Xu and Chung 2024). This points to the need for analysing hegemonic consent-making as an ongoing process shaped by interactions between state and non-state actors, which is never fully realised but continuously pursued.

4 | Ecological Statecraft for Hegemonic Visions

We propose 'ecological statecraft' to examine the practices through which the strategically positioned state actors selectively politicise ecological issues, mobilise resources and engage other state, quasi-state and non-state actors in attempts to build consent around particular hegemonic ecological visions, particularly during contested policy enforcement.

Statecraft refers to strategies through which dispersed micropowers are selected, retained, and codified into state strategies (Jessop 2007). Building on statecraft, hegemonic visions seek to 'reconcile the particular and the universal by linking the state's purposes to a broader—but always selective—political, intellectual and moral vision of the public interest,' which in fact privileges 'some material and ideal interests' (Jessop 2010, 48). Note that Jessop, who famously conceptualises the state as a social relation, rejects any singular notion of 'state power.' In this vein, the 'strategically positioned' state actors refer to actors with disproportionate capacities to set priorities and shape relations with other actors, whose such capacities are essentially unstable and contingently shaped (Deng et al. 2026c).

At the same time, we must ground this relational understanding in China. The Communist Party of China (CPC) and the central government—although themselves far from monolithic—largely overlap in their real function and occupy a strategically significant position (Deng and Xin 2027). Therefore, when the 'state' or 'state power' is explicitly used by us, it refers primarily to the 'state apparatus' as a set of institutions not limited to formal state organisations and functioning primarily through ideology in the service of ruling-class interests (Althusser 2014). This relational understanding of the state helps explain a process of 'strategic statization' in China, which means that 'the state dominates the definition of priorities and orchestrates diverse stakeholders to achieve them' (Feng and Wu 2026, 1). In this paper, we trace this process in ecological space-making. In China, these interests belong not to a capitalist class but to the CPC and its associated interest groups (Wu et al. 2024). From the perspective of state entrepreneurialism, Chinese statecraft operates at the frontier between territorial and capitalist logics (Deng 2023; Wu et al. 2024). A dominant territorial logic foregrounds extra-economic objectives in the production of green spaces (Deng et al. 2026a), where consent-crafting is increasingly becoming central to state-building.

Thus, the 'hegemonic ecological vision' is primarily associated with the CPC, while the 'ecological statecraft' through which it is pursued is constituted through trans-scalar and beyond-state contestations and dynamics. This is where Pike's (2023) geographical approach to statecraft becomes useful for building the analytical framework. This approach builds on the understanding of the state as a work in progress, whose attributes and forms are shaped by temporal and geographical contexts. To spatialise statecraft, Pike et al. (2019, 79) extend the concept to encompass 'the practice of government and governance and governmental inter-relations at the national and local levels within cities and city-regions, central–local relations between national and local governments, and in relations with other para-state[1] and non-state actors in the private and civic sectors.' Analytically, 'ecological statecraft' highlights the selective politicisation of ecological issues during ecological territorialisation, moving beyond technocratic and bureaucratic interventions. It also provides a long-term perspective on the everyday lives of heterogeneous social groups (Wang 2024), attending to both processes of deterritorialisation (Hsing 2010; Smith 2021) and forms of agency (Rodenbiker 2023).

Literature on Chinese ecological governance has pointed to a broader interest in state-building beyond land-based revenues, prompting closer examination of evolving hegemonic visions. By urbanisation of the state, Hsing (2010, 6) argues that urban construction has expanded 'from an accumulation project to a territorial project of local state building' in that the urban process shapes the territorial logic of the state. Rodenbiker (2023, 98) explicitly foregrounds ecological meanings as key to state building in ecological territorialisation, which facilitates forms of development 'dually oriented toward conservation and economic interests.' Deng et al. (2026a) note a growing willingness among local governments to 'align with' central mandates, while the specific meanings of these mandates are continuously reshaped through both central–local interactions and negotiations within central ministries (Yeh 2023).

Evolving hegemonic visions are shaped by deliberate deterritorialisation and reterritorialisation in ecological governance through eco-scalar fixes (Cohen and Bakker 2014). In China, deterritorialisation disempowers and reconfigures villagers' positions, while reterritorialisation selectively empowers certain groups and mobilises support to marginalise others (Hsing 2010). Depoliticisation, in turn, can generate politicised forms of everyday participation, including contestation and the articulation of alternative eco-aesthetics (Pow 2018).

Politicisation is driven not only by grassroots actors but also by multi-tier Party elites (Chung et al. 2018; Chung and Xu 2021; Deng et al. 2026a; Pow and Neo 2013), particularly

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municipal Party Secretaries, who are upwardly accountable within the party-state. This aligns with a shift of focus from bureaucratic control to the infrastructural power of ecological civilisation (Yeh 2023). Beyond formal state organisations, Deng et al. (2026a) use 'strategic embeddedness' to describe how state centrality is maintained through the market and call for extending this analysis to society. Drawing from historical-materialist UPE, it is important to closely examine the coexistence of depoliticisation and repoliticisation (Cohen and Bakker 2014)—or selective politicisation—of ecological issues by state elites through processes of deterritorialisation and reterritorialisation (Deng et al. 2026a; Hsing 2010).

This opens a promising avenue for bridging the historical-materialist tradition and Southern UPE perspectives in analysing the constitution of Chinese state power through the politicised production of ecological spaces by both state elites and grassroots actors. We follow Pike et al.'s (2019, 83) approach to statecraft by explicitly considering the involvement of 'para-state, non-state private, civic and hybrid institutions.' The Southern everyday UPE resonates with such an understanding and further compensates for the statecraft approach's focus on institutions and formal organisations by making more visible the 'subtle and mundane ways in which people are made governable' (Truelove and Cornea 2021, 239). A combination of the statecraft and everyday UPE perspectives enables us to examine China's rapidly evolving ecological governance, in which central and local governments have remained dominant, while increasingly diverse interests, discontent, alternative practices and contestations have emerged from the grassroots and are co-shaping governance in subtle yet critical ways (Shao and Xie 2026). It also enables us to explore pluralised forms of environmental governmentality, including alternative subjectivities that emerge beyond the environmentally conscious neoliberal subjects in China through emergent eco-urbanism programmes and experiments (Mai et al. 2023; Wang et al. 2023).

We understand everyday social agency within hegemonic visions as active and constitutive. The decentred power of practice (Truelove and Cornea 2021) contributes to centrally framed ideology in China precisely because boundaries between state and non-state identities are increasingly blurred in everyday governance (Wang et al. 2025). This is evident in the re-imagining of the neighbourhood as an institution of environmental governance within emergent eco-urbanism, shaped by both bottom-up and top-down processes (Lin and Kao 2020). This everyday dimension reveals that local discontent is not only suppressed but can also be strategically mobilised. Hegemony depends on social and material conditions that are not pre-given in statecraft but are continuously produced. In Chengdu, these conditions are shaped through competition among formal state actors over land-use categories, as well as among non-state and quasi-state actors—such as (former) villagers, state-owned enterprises (SOEs) and urban residents—over operational forms of tourism and through negotiations, claims and disputes over ecological space. This is where quasi-state actors—primarily managers and staff from SOEs and grassroots community organisations—gain importance, as they serve as intermediaries between the state and non-state actors, whose boundaries are often blurred, while also undertaking extensive day-to-day operations and practical tasks. The framework also entails moving beyond accumulation-based explanations toward a more accurate account of uneven gains and losses across social groups in the production of hegemonic visions.

5 | Chengdu Eco-Zone

The Chengdu Eco-Zone refers to a 187 km^2 belt area surrounding the central city, historically a mix of rural villages and sporadic construction (Figure 1). Since the late 1990s, agricultural land in the area has been eroded by accelerated construction, resulting in fragile ecosystems, disrupted water systems, polluted soils and declining fertility.

In the early 2000s, the municipal government adopted the European 'green belt' to delineate a zone to contain urban sprawl (Table 1). This goal was not achieved. In 2007, the central government approved Chengdu as a pilot city for 'urban-rural integration reform,' in the name of addressing uneven development. In practice, this involved clearing 'redundant' constructions in the Eco-Zone to free up land quotas for construction. Villagers' homesteads were cleared and converted into development land quotas, initially used for property and industrial projects and, in the 2010s, increasingly for large-scale ecological projects. The Tianfu Greenway project (Zhang et al. 2022), launched in 2017, exemplifies this state-led landscaping catering to urban middle-class aesthetics. A municipal SOE, the Greenway Corporation, was established to build the greenway and massive landscaped areas (Deng et al. 2026a). However, since the 2020s, state-led farmland restoration has returned half of the Eco-Zone to agricultural use. A subsidiary of the Greenway Corporation, Greenway Agriculture Company (GAC), has been responsible for the Eco-Zone farmland restoration since 2021.

The Eco-Zone is a representative case for understanding how ecological statecraft constructs hegemonic visions for three reasons. First, it reflects common dynamics and trends in Chinese cities, especially long-term peri-urban land conflicts, the recent popularity of greenway development, and policy mandates for the protection of farmland and ecological space under Territorial Spatial Planning (Deng 2026). Second, conflicts and contestations over land use and ecological significance are particularly pronounced in the Chengdu Eco-Zone, making it suitable for analysing the diverse interests and aspirations of multiple actors. Third, the case enables a longitudinal perspective on villagers' and residents' experiences, as well as on the formation and evolution of ecological statecraft. This offers insights applicable to other cases of ecological territorial governance in wider contexts.

Fieldwork took place across five phases between June 2018 and September 2024. First, we recruited interviewees combining purposive sampling and social networks, initially targeting key positions within the municipal government and greenway corporations. In total, we conducted 89 semi-structured interviews with 42 government officials at the

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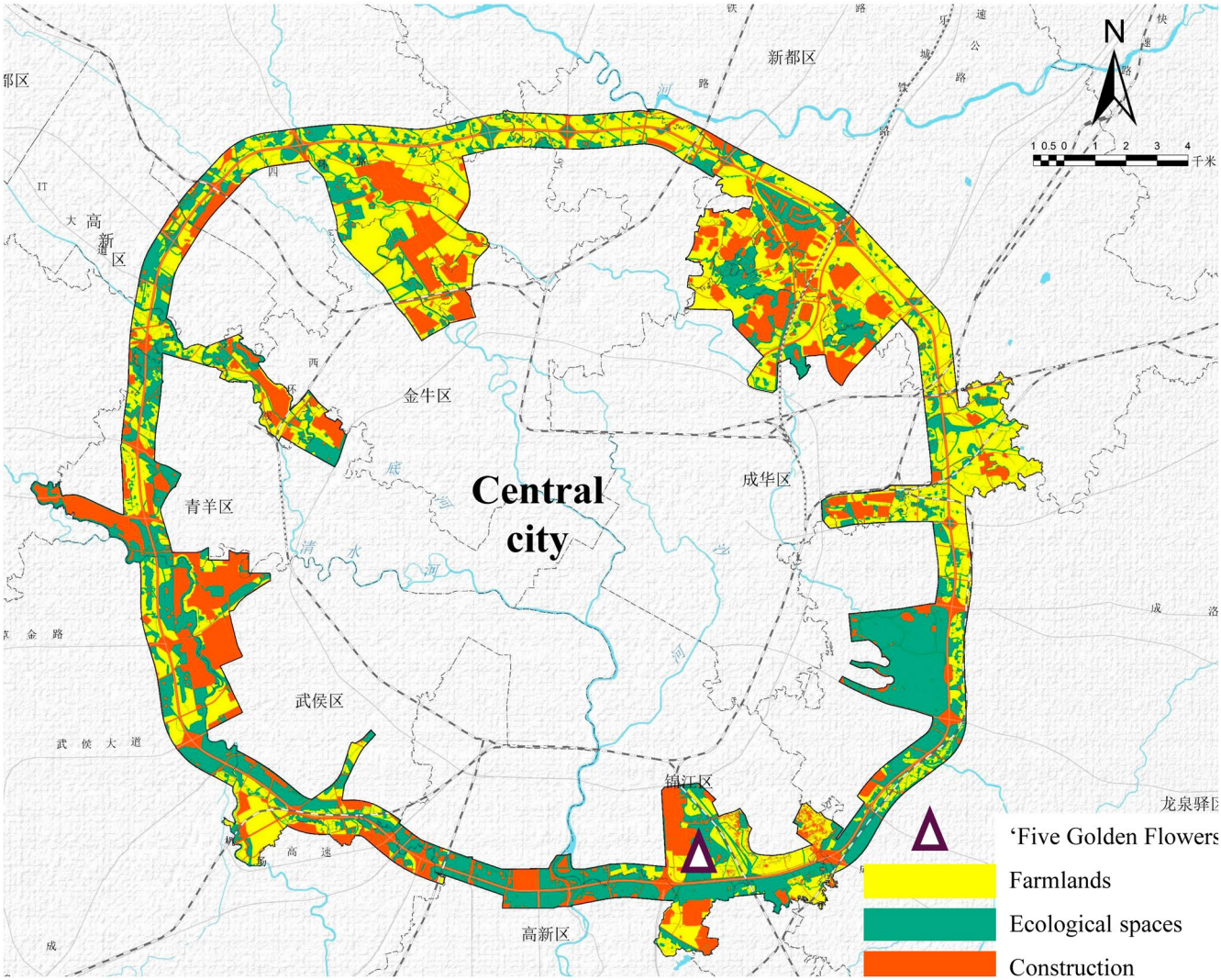


FIGURE 1 | The Chengdu Eco-Zone (adapted from Chengdu Municipal Bureau of Planning and Natural Resources).

provincial, municipal, district and street levels (including two provincial and two senior municipal officials), 22 SOE and private-sector managers (including three senior managers), 14 planners, nine residents (including three former villagers) and two agricultural workers. Second, we attended public events, including a district government-led training course on park management (livestream), a workshop on greenway businesses co-organised by a local semi-official commercial society and planners (in person), and the fourth 'Park City Forum' (livestream). We took notes and saved presentation materials for coding. Third, on-site observations included an official-guided visit across all sections of the 100 km first-tier greenway in 2023 and independent visits to the 100 km greenway by bicycle and on foot in different seasons (2020, 2023, 2024). We took notes of the changes in agricultural landscapes, the workflows of officials and SOE staff, and the activities of visitors, farm machinery and workers. Besides the fieldwork, this research is informed by the positionality of one author, a Chengdu resident who has lived near or within the Eco-Zone since 2004—first as a migrant renter in a post-resettlement villager apartment, and later in a commercial estate within the 'urban construction' area (see Table 2).

Documentary analysis established the temporal and regulatory context at both national and local levels. We sourced a wide range of documents spanning from 2001 to 2025, in digital and print formats, including legislative and regulatory records, master and implementation plans, government speeches and minutes, media articles (mostly post-2011), online citizen forums, census and archival data (2001–2024) and scholarly publications. Materials were gathered via targeted keyword searches (e.g., ecological civilisation, Park City, food security, farmland restoration, villager relocation, greenway) and supplemented by internal documents obtained during fieldwork.

We analysed the data through open and axial coding, first conducting independent open coding and then group-based axial coding to merge the codes into broader analytical categories. We prioritised triangulation across sources and used iterative coding to examine why inconsistencies emerged among corporate, official and resident narratives. We reflexively analysed these divergences and retained them to inform our conceptualisation, recognising that each articulated a partial 'truth'. We also identified widely shared commonalities—for example, consensus on maintaining the total area of urban construction and

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TABLE 1 | Changing governance of Chengdu Eco-Zone: Planning, regulation and livelihoods.

	2001–2007	2008–2016	2017–2020	2020-present
Dominant rationale	Containing urban sprawl	Clearing construction for land development quotas	Greenway development for 'Park City'	Farmland restoration for national food security
Geopolitical and national politics	China joined the WTO in 2001 and the 'Go-West' strategy (2001) accelerated Chengdu's industrialisation and urbanisation.	Post-2008 (global financial crisis) industrial transfer from the coastal regions to Chengdu.	The State Council and the MNR mandated subnational governments to delineate three 'redlines' (ecological, agricultural and urban development boundaries) with the Territorial Spatial Planning reform (2019).	The MNR reiterated prohibiting non-agricultural use of farmlands (2020). The Third National Land Survey results were published (2021). During the survey, the MNR accused Chengdu for not preserving farmlands well.
Local politics	'Urban–rural Integration Reform' was launched locally in 2003, becoming a national pilot in 2007.	'World-class Modern Garden City' (2009), proposed by the then-municipal government leadership. Planned suburban new towns beyond the Eco-Zone, which would separate them from the existing central urban area and contain continuous urban sprawl. 'Urban–rural Integration Reform' was used by districts and municipal governments to expropriate land from villagers and generate developmental quota.	Party Secretary Fan Ruiping (2017–2021) proposed a municipal-wide 'Tianfu Greenway' plan and launched the Eco-Zone greenway project (2017). President Xi Jinping inspected Chengdu and proposed 'Park City' (2018). The municipal leadership rebranded the Eco-Zone greenway as a demonstration project for the 'Park City.'	Chengdu was recognised as a national demonstration zone of 'Park City' in 2022 (Deng et al. 2026a). The Chengdu Plain was identified as a national food production base in the Chengdu Municipal Territorial Spatial Plan (approved by the State Council in 2024).
Eco-Zone planning and regulations	Eco-Zone initially delineated: 500-m buffer areas on both sides of the Fourth Ring Road (opened in 2001) and seven wedges stretching into the central city. 'Urban–rural Integration Plan for Non-Urban Construction Land' identified a peri-urban '198 km^2 area' for construction control (2007).	The '198 Area Upgrading Plan' (2010) designated Eco-Zone as a mixed-use area of farmlands, ecological spaces and service industries. The Chengdu Eco-Zone Protection Law (2013) reduced the '198 km^2 area' to 187 km^2, and prescribed the planning areas of construction, farmlands, and ecological spaces. District governments built wetland parks and lakes for property and tourism development.	The municipality established the Greenway Corporation to build the Eco-Zone greenway (2018), which consolidated regulatory and development rights from districts to the municipal level. Landscaping took place on both 'farmlands' and 'ecological spaces' of the planning areas.	The municipality established the GAC (as a subsidiary of the Greenway Corporation) to manage farmland restoration (2021). The 'Eco-Zone Comprehensive Land Consolidation Plan' was compiled by the Municipal Planning and Natural Resources Bureau (MPNRB) (2021).

(Continues)

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TABLE 1 | (Continued)

	2001–2007	2008–2016	2017–2020	2020-present
Livelihoods	Eco-Zone population grew from 220,000 villagers in 2004 to 260,000 in 2007. Some districts encouraged villagers to operate tourism businesses.	71,700 villagers were relocated by twelve districts to generate quota for transferable development rights. Rural tourism businesses were welcomed by urban residents.	138,300 villagers were relocated by twelve district governments to develop the Eco-Zone greenway and landscaping. Rural tourism businesses were upgraded by district governments and village collectives to cater for urban aesthetics.	50,000 villagers remained. A few rural tourism businesses remained. Agricultural landscaping attracted urban visitors.

Source: Collated by authors. Data of villagers were from the 'Eco-Zone Comprehensive Land Consolidation Plan' compiled by the MPNRB and triangulated through interviews with officials in July 2023.

the importance of ecological quality (despite divergent views on what constitutes it). Within these alignments, we identify a hegemonic project in the making.

6 | Selective Politicisation

The transformation of ecological spaces was predicated on a discursive strategy that framed the peripheral urban Chengdu as a dysfunctional space. Since the mid-2000s, the municipal government has framed the historical Chengdu Eco-Zone as an area characterised by '*zang*' (dirty), '*luan*' (messy and chaotic) and '*cha*' (low-quality). Such a historical image was used to justify the greenway and ecological improvement programs, which were sporadically launched by local district governments and later upscaled into a municipal strategy. Especially post-2017, the municipal government justified the greenway project as an inevitable and universally beneficial act of urban improvement. The following excerpt from a publicity article is a typical framing:

> The Eco-Zone used to be a typical urban–rural fringe. With rapid urban development, large areas of land were used for factories, warehouses and markets. Discarded materials and construction waste accumulated throughout the area, resulting in the continuous loss of agricultural function and degradation of ecological services.
>
> (Excerpt from 'Chengdu Eco-Zone: An Urban Ecological Necklace Constructed According to a Coherent Blueprint 2023', Chinese translated by the authors.)

Environmental legislation and administration also transformed the Eco-Zone into more 'governable' spaces through detailed land-use categories. The delineation defined boundaries, prescribed permitted and prohibited activities, and introduced a simplified logic for the function of ecological spaces. This logic was already evident in earlier planning regulations and has become even more explicit under Territorial Spatial Planning (Yeh 2023). In the Eco-Zone, the areas allocated to three types of space—farmland, ecological space and construction land (Table 2)—were formally specified in the Chengdu Eco-Zone Protection Law, which came into effect in 2013 (Table 1). They were reported to the central MNR in 2014 (Interview with official, July 2023), when the MNR mandated local governments to identify and protect 'basic farmlands.'

Despite directives on farmland protection, municipal officials utilised land use categorisation to classify 'excessive' construction as illegal and to prohibit unwanted activities, which was widely observed across the country (Lin 2009; Rodenbiker 2023). Bureaucratic and technocratic regulations are often combined with large-scale state ecological programmes, including population relocation, reducing them to technocratic calculations and thereby deterritorialising villagers (Hsing 2010) and depoliticising ecological issues (Pow 2018). The saved land quota is often used by local authorities in pursuit of a 'modern' landscape attractive to higher-class residents and advanced service sectors, such as exhibition and high-tech industries, which tend

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TABLE 2 | Land use regulations of the Chengdu Eco-Zone.

Land rights	Land use categories	Planning (km^2)	Reality (km^2)			Competing logics and actors
			2009	2020	2023	
Ownership by village collectives, *contractual right* by villagers, and *operation right* transferable[a] ('Three Rights Separation')	Non-construction, which includes:	133.12	98.11	96.13	123.34	—
	Farmlands	67.34	63.67	40.53	67.34	Farmland protection (central MNR), tourism (districts, tourism corporations and villagers), natural amenities (urban residents), and urban image (municipality)
	Ecological spaces (grasslands, forests, wetlands, water, greenways)	65.78	34.44	55.6	56	Rural functions (central MNR), natural amenities (homeowners and urban residents), and landscaping for 'Park City' (municipality, districts)
Before expropriation: ownership by villagers (homesteads). After expropriation: *Ownership* by the state, and the *use right* transferable	Urban construction	54.04	81.47	78.33	63.82	Marginalised villagers, property appreciation (homeowners, developers), and local industrial development (districts)
Total	—	187.16	179.58[b]	187.16	187.16	—

[a]The term of operation right transfer contracts shall not exceed the remaining term of the land contract. The second round of land contracts in Chengdu will generally expire in 2027 or 2028 (Interview, July 2023).
[b]This figure excluded approximately 7.8 km^2 (the '*Shiling Area*') in the eastern section of the Eco-Zone.
Source: Chengdu Eco-Zone Protection Law (planning data) 2010 '198 Area Upgrading Plan' (2009 data), 2021 Eco-Zone Comprehensive Land Consolidation Plan (2020 data), interviews and records of the Municipal Planning and Natural Resources Bureau (2023 data).

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to marginalise the ecological knowledge and imaginaries of the original communities (Xie et al. 2019).

Meanwhile, Cohen and Bakker (2014) argue that depoliticisation and politicisation operate simultaneously to privilege certain resources or goals. In the Chengdu Eco-Zone, this is evident in the reformulation of hegemonic visions in response to shifting internal and external conditions (Jessop 2010). The municipal government's leading officials have therefore selectively politicised ecological issues—such as farmland versus ecological space—both within the party-state and in their outward framing to the public.

In the 2000s, Chengdu branded itself as a 'World-class Modern Garden City', propelled by the then-Party Secretary. In practice, the strategy was to build satellite towns outside the Eco-Zone. However, the then-Party Secretary was accused of corruption in 2013 and jailed in 2015. The concept of 'Garden City' was abandoned, but local governments continued obtaining land from villagers. Since the 2010s, a key strategy has been to align local programmes with 'ecological civilisation,' a pattern not unique to Chengdu (Chung and Xu 2021). This official narrative claimed that cities should go beyond mere economic growth at the sacrifice of ecological environments (Deng et al. 2026a) and instead pursue 'high-quality development,' another central discourse. In 2017, the city seized an opportunity to rebrand itself as the 'Park City' following Xi's inspection of Chengdu in February 2018. The original intent behind the 'Park City' concept is unclear, but local officials, particularly then Party Secretary Fan Ruiping, were excited about it. They viewed this as an opportunity to politically brand Chengdu as a city that embodies the ethos of 'ecological civilisation' and harmonises green development with environmental quality (Interview, November 2023).

Local officials and planners acknowledged that they did not fully understand what the President meant by 'Park City' (Interview, July 2023). They struggled to form a concrete vision and therefore sought insights from the intellectual community and market consultants (Interview with staff, June 2023). In April 2019, the first 'Park City Forum' was held (Zhang et al. 2022). The municipal government invited speakers from universities, research institutes, enterprise leaders and government officials from Chengdu, nationwide and globally to share their interpretations of the 'Park City.' Besides, the municipal official planning institution, the Chengdu Institute of Planning and Design (CDIPD), organised special sessions on the Annual National Planning Conference for 3 years.

Nevertheless, these events were more about branding than consultancy, or about mobilising big names in academia to justify the municipal strategy without having to follow the experts' recommendations. For example, despite long-lasting scholarly debates over wilderness versus landscaped approaches, the shift toward rewilderness in the greenway project around 2020 was driven by land-use policies that prohibited urban-style park landscaping on rural, collectively owned land (Interview with planner, July 2023). Rather, municipal officials sought to establish an 'accurate' interpretation of the 'Park City' by drawing on another speech by Xi Jinping in Beijing in April 2018,[2] namely to 'build a city within parks' (Interview with official, November 2023). This 'finding' involved selective alignment between municipal and central discourses (Xu and Chung 2024), because Fan Ruiping was eager to promote his 'Tianfu Greenway' plan as a demonstration project of the 'Park City' (Interview with planner, July 2023; SOE senior executive, September 2024).

Politicisation became even more pronounced after the central government elevated national and food security to an unprecedented priority in response to geopolitical tensions. In 2020, the MNR reiterated its prohibition on the 'non-agricultural use' of farmland.[3] The regulation existed before but was often violated by local governments (Lin 2009). During the Third National Land Survey (2018–2020), the Chengdu Eco-Zone's excessive landscaping was accused by MNR officials of violating agricultural functions (Interview with official, July 2023). Chengdu Plain was criticised in general,[4] and the Eco-Zone was a typical case due to its immense area. Intensified inspections increased pressure on local officials. This coincided with the Territorial Spatial Planning reform, under which the MNR required local governments to define and enforce three 'redlines,' particularly the farmland protection redline. Besides, local planners (Interview, July 2023) noted that satellite imagery enabled central authorities to verify land use and monitor remotely, making local non-compliance increasingly difficult.

Contestations over land-use functions among multi-level government officials were intensified. Beyond the alleged misuse of farmland for landscaping, MNR officials also argued that hardened surfaces (such as greenways and parking lots) in the 'ecological spaces' (Table 2) misused rural land for 'urban functions' (Interview with official, July 2023). However, municipal authorities contended that greenways are 'non-construction' land. They referred to a policy after the 2008 earthquake, when the central government granted Chengdu a special land category, 'green economy'—rural collectively owned areas designated for ecological tourism and landscaping. In contrast, the MNR considered the greenways as *de facto* urban construction, because the greenways primarily served urban residents, so they ought to be designated as an urban park and a type of urban development. In response, municipal officials contended that the greenways were also used by tractors and ploughing machines and therefore should be classified as a hybrid of urban and rural land (Interview, July 2023).

However, food security and farmland protection have increasingly become an un-negotiable issue. Municipal and district officials mentioned their efforts to secure central government support through a proposal called *zhizheng buzhuan*—converting rural land to state ownership while retaining its non-construction functions (see Table 2 for distinctions) (Interview, June 2023). Several senior officials travelled to Beijing to lobby the MNR but failed (Interview, July 2023).

The political tactics of local government leaders also became increasingly subordinated to centralised institutionalisation. In August 2021, Fan Ruiping was removed from his position, and he did not get promoted. A new Party Secretary, Shi Xiaoling, was appointed. The Greenway Corporation established a subsidiary, the GAC, to carry out farmland restoration just 1 month after Shi assumed her position. Fan's flagship greenway project was not suspended but re-oriented.

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In turn, the central government leveraged the municipal strategy of 'Park City' to reinforce local enforcement of the central ethos (Deng et al. 2026a). Chengdu was officially designated a 'national demonstration zone' of Park City in 2022. Unlike the President's personal endorsement in 2018, this represents formal recognition by three central ministries: National Development and Reform Commission, MNR and Ministry of Housing and Urban–Rural Development (Interview with official, September 2024). The recognition was predicated on the municipal government's 'correct understanding of the ethos of ecological civilisation and high-quality development' and tangible efforts in farmland restoration (Interview with official, September 2024). By 2023, nearly all designated farmland in the Eco-Zone had been 'correctly used' and had 'passed MNR review' (Interview with official, November 2023), following large-scale conversion from landscaped areas to farmland by the GAC (Table 2).

7 | Local Statecraft

Between 2008 and 2022, ecological zoning and greenway development led to the relocation of 210,000 villagers into 51 government-built apartment compounds (Table 1). The resettlement unfolded alongside household registration (hukou) reforms in Chengdu since 2003. The reforms, later incorporated into the national pilot for urban–rural integration (Table 1), sought to dismantle the institutional divide between rural and urban residency. In the 2000s, obtaining urban *hukou* registration required giving up rural land, so few villagers opted in. In the 2010s, integration instead extended quasi-urban welfare without removing land rights, including for relocated villagers in the Eco-Zone (Interview, July 2023).[5] Household statuses were strategically split: within a family, some members adopted an urban *hukou* while others retained rural ones. Those whose land was expropriated received urban hukou and full social security; those who kept rural hukou retained collective land rights and shares in the village collective. Similar arrangements have been observed in other regions (Bray 2013). To accelerate greenway development after 2017, villagers with rural *hukou* received a specialised municipal welfare rate at half the standard level. To finance this, the municipal government allowed districts higher floor-area ratios in designated construction zones, using land revenues to fund welfare (Interview, July 2023).

In such a 'buying stability' (Lee and Zhang 2013; Wang 2024) form of statecraft in quickly implementing such a grand project, economic marginalisation was secondary to the dismantling of the village as a meaningful social form (Smith 2021). Over recent decades, the shift from villagers to urban residents has deepened, especially as younger generations attend urban public schools, enter the workforce and adopt urban identities. Although around 50,000 villagers formally retained collective land rights, most now rely on tourism and non-agricultural activities. They developed rural-themed guesthouses, restaurants and recreational services (known as *nongjiale*), reshaping the Eco-Zone's natural and cultural landscapes.

One example is the 'Five Golden Flowers' area (a series of five themed scenic spots) in the Jinjiang District (southeastern section of the Eco-Zone, Figure 1), launched following the urban–rural integration reform in the 2000s. Consistent with Rodenbiker's (2023) observations in the northern peri-urban Chengdu, the villagers were entrepreneurial and corporatised. Apart from operating their own *nongjiale* businesses on homesteads, they established collectively owned enterprises and signed contracts with other firms to transfer the operation rights of farmlands, typically used for flower viewing, vegetable cultivation, dining and leisure. The area became one of the most popular local weekend destinations for urban residents.

These activities shaped the specific visions of a hegemonic ecological project from below. Before 2020, districts and even the municipal government leadership in general supported *nongjiale* for their employment and economic contributions.[6] Districts incorporated villager-produced landscapes—such as *nongjiale* and flower fields—into narratives of ecological quality. Municipal Party Secretary Fan Ruiping (2017–2021) reinforced this narrative, for example, by publicly promoting 'enjoying hot pot on the greenway' as part of Chengdu's lifestyle and his 'Tianfu Greenway' plan.[7]

However, post-2020s central directives mandating farmland restoration have required some plots to revert to grain production (Deng and Xin 2027). Such intensified trans-scalar tensions between the central mandate, which is less development-oriented in pursuing ecological visions, and locally embedded socioeconomic interests at the village and district levels place the municipal government in a mediating position. The municipal government performs this mediating role while pursuing its own strategic interest in making metropolitan Chengdu an attractive 'Park City' characterised by human–nature harmony (Deng et al. 2026a).

In managing these relations, approaches have become increasingly flexible and extend beyond typical state actors. Quasi-state actors, represented by the Greenway Corporation and the GAC, play a growing role. The municipal government gave the GAC the mandate for farmland restoration. It signed operating rights contracts with village collectives and, by 2023, had assumed control of 90% of the Eco-Zone's farmland for unified planning and management (Interview, July 2023).

Fan Ruiping invited a businessperson who had successfully operated a private rural cultural tourism business in a town in Chengdu to serve as chairperson of the Greenway Corporation (the parent company of the GAC), with certain political career prospects promised. She was more experienced in operating 'real businesses' than other SOE leaders, who were former bureaucrats. After branding the Greenway as an attractive tourism destination and a viable business case, she continued to manage the agricultural businesses to meet both political mandates and basic business operational requirements ('not lose too much') (Interview, July 2023). The role of the Greenway Corporation's chairperson reflects the fluidity between non-state and quasi-state actors in strategically crucial positions, as the appointment was made by the municipal government leadership. A key distinction from earlier rural tourism corporations (Rodenbiker 2023), including those in the 'Five Golden Flowers' and the other subsidiaries of the Greenway Corporation, is that the GAC is not profit-oriented. Profitability is not part of its performance evaluation. It is

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designed solely to restore and maintain the mandated farmland within the Eco-Zone. Its limited commercial activities aim not to generate profit but to offset losses and ease post-pandemic fiscal pressures. The company relies heavily on subsidies from its parent corporation and targeted government agricultural support.

The MPNRB officials commented that they had 'no choice' but to rely on SOEs due to the urgency of the political mandate:

> The central government passed down the mandate [of farmland restoration]. We had to enforce it. We have very few approaches to choose from. Integrated and machinery farming is a feasible way to achieve the cascaded goals.
>
> (Interview, July 2023)

The mandate was used to justify the consolidation of operational rights over smallholders or private corporations. When asked about the rationale behind SOE involvement, the GAC executives explained that:

> Villagers would be unwilling to farm because of the low profitability. They have been recruited into the urban economy. They prefer to live in the service, tourism, or delivery industries in the city. It has to be an SOE to undertake the mandate nowadays.
>
> (Interview, July 2023)

It is important to note that district and municipal authorities were precisely the actors who urbanised these villagers over the past decades. Moreover, while the current narrative emphasises public interest, it marginalises smallholder farmers, largely due to perceived market inefficiency and lack of economies of scale.

The GAC has developed recreational and tourism activities due to the fiscal pressures of subsidising agriculture (discussed in greater detail in Deng et al. 2026b). The municipal government supported these initiatives through policies, including one that allowed agricultural tourism projects to use 5% of their land for construction, providing space for facilities and campsites. New homestay and catering operators must rent both land and facilities from the company to operate their businesses. The company has operated experience farms and encouraged citizens to adopt plots. In the rice planting season, a few paddy fields are opened for the public to experience rice planting and fish touching. Fees are charged for some farming experience activities. However, profitability remained secondary to farmland restoration, and these activities have so far generated limited profits (Interview with official, November 2023).

The GAC did not acquire the operational rights to all agricultural land in the Eco-Zone, reflecting the ongoing contestation over land-use rights among villages and townships (more or less supported by the districts) and the municipal government (Hsing 2010). The remaining land not taken over by the GAC, such as 'Five Golden Flowers,' represents relatively mature economic interests in these spaces. District governments are responsible for promoting agricultural farming (Interview, July 2023). This has, however, constrained tourism activities and generated local discontent, as many flower fields were converted to food crops. To consolidate smaller plots into larger, machine-operable farms, districts implemented financial buyouts targeting rural homesteads used for *nongjiale* businesses (Interview with planner, June 2023). Compensation was calculated based on the constructed floor area and was particularly high for large operators. One of the largest *nongjiale* operators in the 'Five Golden Flowers' (Interview, June 2023) received RMB 20 million in compensation. District governments also took the opportunity to 'upgrade' remaining tourism businesses by enforcing land consolidation programmes through market-based partnerships rather than forced evictions. District-level SOEs played a role similar to the GAC in consolidating operational rights of farmlands from smaller firms. The firms were comparatively disadvantaged and received minimal compensation, in contrast to villagers' homesteads (Interview, July 2023).

The 'everyday environmental state' has emphasised how non-state actors assume state-like functions (Cornea et al. 2017; Truelove and Cornea 2021). Nowadays, many daily tasks in the Eco-Zone, such as restoring soil fertility, farming, patrols, addressing citizens' concerns and public communication, are delegated to SOEs (Interview, July 2023). Monthly greenway patrols are conducted jointly by MPNRB officers, district officers and the GAC staff. Weekly patrols are carried out by *shequ* (grassroots quasi-administrative units) officers or district-level SOE staff. Dedicated security and environmental patrol posts have also been established, some of which are staffed by former villagers.

These arrangements were launched by municipal authorities, differing from Southern experiences, but similarly open spaces for everyday negotiation because SOE staff, *shequ* officers and patrol workers lack formal civil servant status and operate at the boundary between state authority and local community. Lacking the full authority and instruments of formal bureaucratic offices, they rely on negotiation, persuasion and interpersonal relations, while their embeddedness in local communities enables discretion in balancing competing interests. As one *shequ* officer in a community developed by a private developer reflected:

> First of all, I can tell you that we are not working for the developer. We are an organisation listening to the Party. Of course, I want the environment to be better so that our community will be more attractive. This is also what our residents want. But things are not that simple, and we deal with many different issues every day.
>
> (Interview, November 2023)

This resembles the everyday governance identified in Southern cities, where public authority is exercised through heterogeneous actors and blurred state–society boundaries (Cornea et al. 2017). Recent research on Shanghai community gardens

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similarly shows how community-level governance is assembled through interactions among formal state agencies, community as *de facto* state actors and civil society organisations (Shao and Xie 2026). Such practices become particularly important when fiscal resources and formal administrative instruments are insufficient to secure implementation through bureaucratic command alone.

8 | Incomplete Hegemony

In addressing the fundamental concern by UPE 'who produces what kind of socio-ecological configurations for whom' (Heynen et al. 2006, 2) of the uneven ecological territorialisation, Rodenbiker (2023) cautions against framing villagers as passive victims, noting that some peri-urban households have actively negotiated ecological relocation to maximise compensation. Xie and Den Hartog (2026) more explicitly engage UPE with the Chinese authoritarian context and propose further studying the unevenness caused by state-led grand ecological programmes.

Extending these, we find that through tourism entrepreneurship, eco-aesthetic branding and compensation from farmland restoration, the municipal government deliberately incorporates villagers' practices into the spatial project. Except for collective land ownership, their commercial models and aesthetic production have become increasingly indistinguishable from urban practices, while in turn shaping ecological imaginaries.

There have been geographically uneven losses and gains for villagers. Peri-urban villagers and those in remote counties follow different trajectories, even though both enter the urban labour pool. The GAC hired agricultural workers. According to the staff and interviewed workers, they mostly come from remote suburban districts (which are still rural) in Chengdu. They resemble other migrant workers working in the city, only that they work in the agriculture sector. The operation is highly marketised. A typical daily wage for agricultural workers is between 100 and 300 Yuan. Wages rise when demand increases. It is difficult to recruit residents nearby (who used to be farmers) because most have become accustomed to urban life and can find higher-paying jobs (Interview with GAC staff, July 2023). Yet the wage rate is sufficient to attract villagers from remote areas since most still farm at home, and working at the Eco-Zone is more rewarding than farming at home. Through the GAC, the municipal government sustains an extensive peri-urban farming initiative by leveraging wage differentials across locations. Given these dynamics, it is difficult to claim a net increase in cultivation for food security. The expansion of Eco-Zone agriculture has come at the expense of abandoned farmland in more remote rural areas—an exchange that, despite local ecological gains, undermines broader food production efforts.

Another relevant group is urban residents, particularly middle-class homeowners, who should not be viewed simply as 'urban elites' benefiting at the expense of villagers. In April 2023, several Chengdu-based media outlets reported on the Eco-Zone's farmland restoration, accusing the municipal government of wasting public funds. These reports triggered online debates.[8] The municipal government was compelled to address public discontent after online criticism was identified by the provincial government, which held the municipality accountable.[9]

Municipal officials argued that much opposition came from real estate developers (Interview, July 2023). Indeed, developers, real estate agents and homeowners in the 'construction area' (Table 2) were concerned that farmlands, instead of parks, would reduce property values (Interview with homeowner, June 2023). When marketing properties, real estate agents would present land use plans distinguishing 'basic farmland' (meaning it can only be used for food crops) from 'ordinary farmland' or 'other land' (Interview, June 2023). Whereas some citizens thought that the Eco-Zone would benefit the environment as long as it did not include urban construction and would provide public green space, whether farmland or grassland (Interview with citizen, July 2023).

Fragmented interests among diverse grassroots actors in the Eco-Zone were leveraged by the municipality to build consent. For example, online critiques have focused on the waste of public funds or the low agricultural productivity of heavily polluted soil. These marginalised the nuanced ecological critiques from environmental groups. A local environmental organisation's report[10] on a segment of the Eco-Zone documented several ecological harms, including the impact of tourist boats on wild duck populations, excessive pruning of mature trees critical for bird habitats and the replacement of biodiverse native grasses with manicured lawns. Yet such ecological concerns remained peripheral in mainstream discussion. Besides, the GAC converted the farmlands into visually attractive and social-media-friendly sites, neutralising most opposition.

As such, middle-class homeowners are not simply beneficiaries of environmental improvements. Many homeowners paid hundreds of thousands of yuan in appreciation premiums when purchasing properties, and associated expectations of environmental amenities closely relate to asset value (Deng et al. 2026a). When the municipal government later integrated farming into ecological landscaping schemes, these expectations had to be recalibrated.

Less than a month following the public opinion outbreak, the municipal government and Greenway Corporation organised extensive Eco-Zone visits and check-in activities for media, online influencers and citizen representatives. The events were launched by municipal bureaus of planning and park city management and executed by their officials and the SOE staff. The citizen visitors were shown land-clearance areas with old factory buildings and dilapidated houses, the farmland-restoration areas and the ecological areas of greenways, lakes and parks. The events were promoted as a demonstration of engaging public participation in the Eco-Zone. They even 'elected' citizen supervisors from these participants.[11]

These activities were extensively reported via state-led and quasi-state press and media. The municipal officials rolled out a new slogan: 'Rice paddies are wetlands, and vegetable plots are landscapes'. Besides, the municipal government mobilised

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expert knowledge to present the vision as a win-win outcome of 'parks and fertility.' Cushman & Wakefield was tasked with estimating the indirect economic benefits of the Eco-Zone through consumption, which were said to amount to 'one trillion.'[12] The Chinese Academy of Sciences quantified the carbon reduction and economic value for the municipal government.

Neither villagers nor middle-class residents meaningfully shape core decisions, nor are they exclusively marginalised; instead, they are incorporated into a hegemonic project oriented towards consolidating a particular configuration of state power, currently biased toward the central government.

Meanwhile, voluntaristic market exchange in governance is expanding, which reduces the need for coercion (Kan 2019) and provides the ground for other forms of statecraft closely intertwined with the establishment of quasi-state agents at the grassroots level. Villagers negotiating in market terms, homeowners investing through property premiums, and former villagers employed in greenway patrols all participate in and reproduce hegemonic ecological visions.

Some former villagers continue to grow crops or vegetables not for profit but as a way of life. They care so little about profitability that the municipal government cannot incorporate them into formal plans. We have observed temporary farming on dotted plots around the Eco-Zone. These plots were cleared by the SOE but have not yet been brought into mechanised agriculture. They have since been occupied by former villagers, mostly in their 50s and 60s, who now live in resettlement apartments or commercial housing estates. One explained that they grow vegetables near home for leisure, as it was once their livelihood (Interview, September 2024). Their tactics did not follow a straightforward logic of opposition. For instance, they draw water from nearby drains and rivers that have been restored under state-led environmental programmes. They simply assert alternative ways of inhabiting and understanding the land through their continued presence.

Our interpretation of 'incomplete hegemony' remains primarily state-centred, reflecting the composition and limitations of our fieldwork data. The core argument concerns the intentional incorporation of grassroots actors by strategically significant state actors to deliver political mandates and maintain social stability. Yet even among our limited non-state interviewees, experiences and expectations of ecological interventions varied considerably. This suggests that the hegemonic project remains uneven and incomplete, a dynamic that has recently attracted attention in China but warrants further investigation (see Xie and Den Hartog 2026).

9 | Conclusion

We have examined the changing governance of the Chengdu Eco-Zone over two decades. Developing the framework of ecological statecraft, we argue that ecological spaces constitute a hegemonic project serving the state's strategic interests in China. The hegemonic project seeks to subordinate both accumulation strategies and social life to the territorial logic prioritising sovereignty and stability, but it is never complete. First, specific ecological visions—green space provision, ecological tourism and agricultural farmlands—have intertwined with but extend beyond accumulation strategies. Despite being corporatised, recent land consolidation primarily serves national mandates rather than land value capture. Second, visions evolve in response to changing external and domestic conditions and are co-produced with (former) villagers and urban residents. Strategically positioned politicians and bureaucrats selectively politicise ecological issues to mobilise resources and engage heterogeneous social groups. This does not mean that social actors substantially shape major decisions. Rather, beyond systematic exclusion and deterritorialisation of villagers, the state reterritorialises them through marketised social interactions. Ecological statecraft combines coercive and flexible approaches to building consent in the hegemonic project.

The study makes contributions to the pluralisation of UPE through insights from Chinese ecological governance. First, by bringing statecraft into dialogue with Chinese UPE scholarship on land politics (Hsing 2010; Rodenbiker 2023; Smith 2021), the study highlights extra-economic objectives in the production of ecological space in China. Approaches such as tourism development and land-based revenue generation are therefore contingent and provisional compared with 'ecological civilisation' as a statecraft project (Chen 2025; Deng et al. 2026a; Zhang et al. 2026). This perspective extends historical-materialist UPE traditions, including socio-ecological fixes (Ekers and Prudham 2017; Zhang et al. 2022) and state entrepreneurialism (Wu and Zhang 2026), as applied to Chengdu (Zhang and Wu 2024), by drawing attention to state authority beyond its role as a facilitator of accumulation (Crabb et al. 2024; Parenti 2015) and its growing contradiction with current accumulation strategies.

Second, by bridging statecraft as a constellation of state, quasi-state and non-state actors (Deng et al. 2026c; Pike 2023) with the everyday environmental state perspective in Southern UPE (Cornea et al. 2017), the study develops a framework for analysing the construction of evolving hegemonic ecological visions from the grassroots. This is relevant not only in Southern contexts characterised by institutional 'messiness' (Truelove and Cornea 2021), but also in settings with stronger and more institutionalised state power (Feng and Wu 2026; Shao and Xie 2026; Wang et al. 2025). From this perspective, grassroots actors do not merely subvert or bypass hegemonic ecological visions. They also reproduce them in subtle ways and may play a differently active role in governance than is typically examined within an anti-capitalist framework (Loftus 2012; Tzaninis et al. 2021). Although far from providing a definitive depiction of the operational model of state power across multiple scales (and the existence of such a model is itself questionable from our lens; see also Peck 2026 and Shin et al. 2026), our combination of everyday and statecraft perspectives draws attention to the constitutive role of SOEs, grassroots quasi-state organisations and non-state actors in ecological statecraft in China.

Finally, the paper demonstrates the value of theorising UPE with China to address the historically uneasy relationship between

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political ecology and the state (Loftus 2020). This should not eliminate the critical lens of UPE, for uneven power relations persist and are reinforced in statecraft. UPE, in turn, enriches statecraft studies by moving them beyond an institutional analysis of formal political agencies toward a broader focus on societal transformation (Deng et al. 2026c). In an era in which ecological crises intersect with geopolitical and multi-level state politics, UPE is promising to offer deeper theoretical insight into state power and greater practical relevance.

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Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

Research data are not shared.

Endnotes

[1] They used 'quasi-state' and 'para-state' interchangeably.

[2] Beijing Municipal Forestry and Parks Bureau,15 August 2023, 'Building the Capital City as a Big Garden' (in Chinese) https://yllhj.beijing.gov.cn/ztxx/lhysh/jj/202308/t20230814_3221783.shtml.

[3] State Council, 17 November 2020, 'Opinions on Preventing the "Non-Grain Use" of Agricultural Farmland and Stabilising Grain Production' (in Chinese) https://www.nhc.gov.cn/bgt/gwywj2/202011/ae10ac6ed3aa42ea8f939c834ea635f5.shtml; State Council, 17 September 2020, 'Notice on Resolutely Preventing the "Non-Agricultural Use" of Farmland' (in Chinese) https://www.mee.gov.cn/zcwj/gwywj/202009/t20200917_798781.shtml.

[4] Banyuetan, 12 May 2022, 'Farmland Sharply Decreased by 40% in 10 Years: What Happened to the "Tianfu Grain Barn"?' (in Chinese) https://www.chinanews.com.cn/gn/2022/05-12/9752756.shtml.

[5] 'Opinions Regarding the Unification of Chengdu Urban and Rural Hukou to Achieve Freedom of Movement' (English translation) https://www.cecc.gov/resources/legal-provisions/opinions-regarding-the-unification-of-chengdu-urban-and-rural-hukou-to.

[6] Interestingly, the Greenway Corporation viewed these activities as 'low-end' businesses, partly due to its interest in taking them over; this was disputed by some municipal officials, commenting the Greenway Corporation's 'high-end' business plan was 'unrealistic' (Group interview, July 2023).

[7] 'Fan Ruiping Delivers a Thematic Party Lecture Report in Accordance with the "Remain True to the Original Aspiration and Keep the Mission Firmly in Mind" Education Campaign' (in Chinese) https://www.xinjiapo.news/news/244500.

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